What over- and what undergenerates in Right-Node Raising

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Abstract

Belk et al. (2023) and Barros and Vicente (2011) have argued that Right-Node Raising (RNR) requires a dual analysis, as either multidominance or ellipsis. This paper examines RNR at the subword level (e.g., *over- and undergenerate*) and shows that, like phrasal RNR, subword RNR displays mixed properties diagnostic of both multidominance and ellipsis, supporting a dual analysis at both levels. We argue, however, that the dual approach, as currently implemented, cannot capture certain subword and phrasal RNR data without modification. We therefore propose a modified version of RNR-as-ellipsis, in which focus-marked material can survive ellipsis in situ, and which captures both subword and phrasal RNR, while retaining multidominance as the second component of the dual analysis.

1 Introduction

Right-Node Raising (RNR) is a syntactic configuration in which an element, the so-called pivot, is interpreted as being shared across conjuncts (1). Typically, the pivot – here, *romantasy novels* – surfaces at the right edge of the coordination.

(1) Ahmad likes, but Elly hates, romantasy novels.

How RNR is derived has been the subject of much debate. Recently, a hybrid approach has been gaining traction. Based on a range of diagnostics, Barros and Vicente (2011) and Belk et al. (2023) argue that, in some instances of RNR, the pivot is underlyingly merged twice but elided in the non-final conjunct(s), whereas in others, the pivot is merged only once and multidominated across conjuncts. Following Belk et al., we will refer to these two analyses as RNR-E (ellipis) and RNR-MD (multidominance).

This paper adds to this debate by examining an intriguing and understudied variant of RNR, in which the pivot is smaller than a word (2). Note that in the following, we use the term 'word' purely descriptively.

(2) a. over- and underestimate

b. pre- and post-war

Subword RNR has often been regarded as a distinct, purely morphological phenomenon. Here, we maintain that it should be analyzed on a par with phrasal RNR (see also Chaves, 2008; Wilder, 2008). There is a growing consensus in the field that syntax and morphology do not constitute separate modules but that structures and operations at the subword level

mirror those at the word level, as formulated in frameworks such as Distributed Morphology (Halle and Marantz, 1993, 1994) and Nanosyntax (Caha, 2009; Starke, 2009), among other approaches. Moreover, we will demonstrate that the two variants of RNR have a strikingly similar empirical profile: subword RNR displays the same mixed properties that have motivated a dual multidominance-plus-ellipsis approach to phrasal RNR. Thus, we argue that the subword data provide further evidence for a dual approach to RNR as either multidominance or ellipsis, in line with Barros and Vicente (2011) and Belk et al. (2023).

At the same time, we will also show that the specific ways in which this dual analysis has been fleshed out to account for phrasal RNR do not carry over to subword RNR. First, with respect to RNR-MD, Barros and Vicente (2011) and Belk et al. (2023) have argued that certain properties of RNR can only be derived from a multidominance structure if (part of) the pivot additionally undergoes QR. We show that for subword RNR, this is not a viable analysis, and it is not clear that it is successful for phrasal RNR either. Second, with respect to RNR-E, we argue that subword RNR does not fall out as an instance of well-known forms of ellipsis such as VP ellipsis. Instead, we sketch out a novel approach to ellipsis according to which focus-marked material can escape ellipsis while remaining in situ.

Overall, this paper makes the following contributions. First, while both an ellipsis and a multidominance analysis of subword RNR have been proposed before independently from each other, we systematically present evidence for both syntactic structures, motivating a dual approach parallel to phrasal RNR. Second, we show that previous analyses of RNR, whether multidominance or traditional ellipsis, fail to account for subword and phrasal RNR

data that show characteristics of ellipsis but have no forward-ellipsis counterpart. Third, we propose a new analysis of RNR-E that captures these data at both levels, leaving its broader implications for future research.

Like the vast majority of work on RNR, this paper will be concerned with English data only. This is a clear, and unfortunate, limitation. We hope that future research will look more in detail at the properties of subword RNR cross-linguistically.

We proceed as follows. Section 2 provides an overview over the dual analysis of RNR, and Section 3 gives a general introduction to subword RNR. Section 4 is concerned with the multidominance (4.1) and ellipsis (4.2) properties of subword RNR. Section 5 concludes.

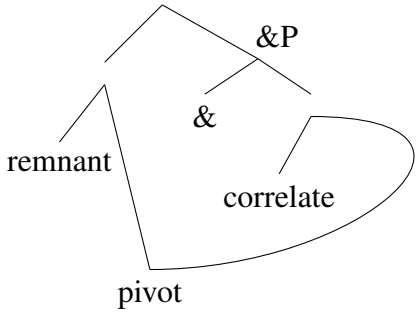
2 The dual multidominance-plus-ellipsis account of RNR

The term Right-Node Raising reflects the old idea that the pivot undergoes rightward across-the-board (ATB) movement out of the coordination (Abbott, 1976; Postal, 1974; Ross, 1967; Sabbagh, 2007, a.o.). Although historically influential, this account faces substantial challenges, as RNR lacks several core properties of movement (see Abels, 2004; McCloskey, 1986; Wexler and Culicover, 1980, a.o.). Instead, two influential alternative analyses have emerged: multidominance and PF-deletion.

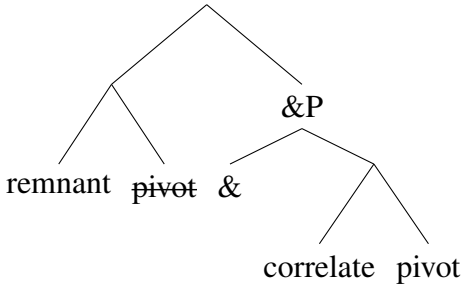
Under the multidominance analysis, the pivot is simultaneously dominated by both conjuncts but is linearized only once, typically at the right edge of the sentence (Bachrach and Katzir, 2009; Citko, 2011a, 2011b; Gračanin-Yuksek, 2007; Johnson, 2007; Wilder, 1999, 2008, a.o.), as in (3). The PF-deletion account, by contrast, posits two copies of the

pivot, with the copy in the first conjunct deleted under identity with the one in the second conjunct, as in (4).

(3)



(4)



The PF-deletion account can itself be subdivided into two major strands, which we will refer to as *prosodic deletion* and *ellipsis*. Under the former, deletion targets prosodic units and requires strict phonological identity (Chaves, 2008, 2014; Hartmann, 2001; Wilder, 1997). By contrast, under an ellipsis analysis, ellipsis is syntactically licensed, and a syntactic constituent in the non-final conjunct(s) is subsequently elided at PF (Aelbrecht, 2010; Ha, 2008; Merchant, 2001, a.o.).

Recent research has advocated a dual multidominance-plus-ellipsis account of RNR, arguing that the properties of the construction resist a unitary analysis (Abels, 2004; Barros and Vicente, 2011; Belk et al., 2023; Citko, 2017).[1] Three diagnostics can be employed to adjudicate between an RNR-E and an RNR-MD analysis. First, if the pivot, when recovered in the first conjunct of the corresponding full coordination, exhibits a phonological form

[1]Note that both Barros and Vicente (2011) and Belk et al. (2023) employ the term *ellipsis* as a descriptive label in their dual analyses, but as in much other research on RNR, they do not make their assumptions about the nature of the PF-deletion operation explicit. Moreover, Barros and Vicente (2011), Belk et al. (2023), and Larson (2012) observe that pivots indicative of RNR-E and RNR-MD may co-occur within a single RNR, albeit subject to ordering restrictions. While similar patterns may also be found in subword RNR, we leave this discussion to future work due to space limitations.

that differs from its form in the RNR construction, then the RNR-MD analysis is ruled out, as it posits a single shared constituent dominated by both conjuncts and therefore cannot accommodate phonological mismatches between the two occurrences. Example (5a) illustrates a morphological mismatch, and (5b) illustrates vehicle change, i.e., an alternation between a pronoun and R-expression.

(5) a. I usually fail to ~~wake up early~~, but Ava always succeeds in waking up early.

b. She hopes that he won't ~~fire her~~, but I fear that the boss will fire Ava.
(Belk et al., 2023:689f.)

Morphological mismatches and vehicle change have also been observed in VP ellipsis, as in (6) (Belk et al., 2023; Bošković, 2004; Ha, 2008, a.o.):

(6) a. Ava always succeeds in waking up early, but I usually fail to ~~wake up early~~.

b. I fear that the boss will fire Ava, although she hopes that he won't ~~fire her~~.
(Belk et al., 2023:689f.)

These properties are thus typically taken as evidence for an RNR-E analysis.

The second diagnostic concerns cumulative agreement, as seen in (7a). Here, the pivot has a different form (*have*) from the element that would be realized in both conjuncts in the corresponding full coordination in (7b) (*has*). Such a form mismatch is unattested in ellipsis, ruling out an ellipsis analysis of these cases.

(7) a. Sue's proud that Bill_{SG}, and Mary's glad that John_{SG}, have $_{\text{PL}}$traveled to Cameroon.

b. Sue's proud that Bill_{SG} has_{SG} traveled to Cameroon, and Mary's glad that John_{SG} has_{SG} traveled to Cameroon. (Grosz, 2015:6)

Cumulative agreement of this kind has been analyzed in both Grosz (2015) and Belk et al. (2023) as being captured by RNR-MD. The multidominated T either undergoes Multiple Agree, whereby two singular values are cumulatively resolved as plural in the syntax (Grosz, 2015), or syntactic agreement is blocked (Belk et al., 2023), such that the predicate's number feature is instead interpreted semantically.

Third, if the interpretations available in the RNR structure differ from those of the full coordination, the RNR-E analysis is ruled out since PF-deletion is assumed to preserve the interpretation(s) of its non-elliptical counterpart. For instance, the pivot in (8a) contains the relational modifier *same*, giving rise to two interpretations. Under the internal reading, the tune hummed by John and the tune sung by Mary are identical. Under the external reading, the tune hummed by John and sung by Mary is identical to a contextually salient tune. Crucially, the internal reading is unavailable in the full coordination in (8b).

(8) a. John whistled, and Mary hummed, the same tune. (Jackendoff, 1972:192)

b. John whistled the same tune, and Mary hummed the same tune.

Similarly, the RNR construction in (9a) allows for a distributive plural reading under which Ava and Habib each study one Oceanic language. This interpretation is unavailable in the full coordination, (9b). Both (9a) and (9b) permit the collective reading, under which Ava and Habib each study more than one Oceanic language.

(9) a. Ava will soon, and Habib is going to, study Oceanic languages.

b. Ava will soon study Oceanic languages, and Habib is going to study Oceanic languages. (Belk et al., 2023:700)

These facts have been argued to be captured by RNR-MD. Internal readings as in (8a) have traditionally been taken to require *same* to scope over the coordination (Carlson, 1987 et seq.). Extending this analysis, Belk et al. (2023) argue that the distributive reading in (9a) can be derived in the same way. They further contend that the absence of a distributive reading in the full coordination in (9b) follows from the unavailability of ATB-QR of *Oceanic languages*, which would otherwise derive the intended interpretation. A multidominance analysis of (9b) is equally unavailable, since pronouncing *Oceanic languages* in both conjuncts violates the linearizability requirement of the modified Linear Correspondence Axiom for multidominance trees (Wilder, 1999, 2008). This observation provides further evidence that ATB-movement, whether overt or covert, should no longer be treated as an alternative to multidominance (see Belk et al., 2023; Citko, 2005, a.o.). Instead, a multidominance analysis of ATB movement can account for both the presence and the absence of distributive readings in (9a) and (9b), respectively.

In sum, the mixed properties of RNR motivate a hybrid multidominance-plus-ellipsis account. While this dual analysis has been well established for phrasal RNR, we show later that subword RNR has the same mixed properties. The next section first gives an overview over subword RNR in general.

3 Subword RNR

Coordination below the word level is cross-linguistically a widespread phenomenon. It is particularly well-studied under the label of suspended affixation in agglutinative languages such as Turkish, Korean and Uralic languages, where the pivot – the 'suspended' material – is typically an inflectional affix or string of affixes (e.g., Atmaca, 2020; Broadwell, 2008; Despić, 2017; Dolatian, 2022; Erschler, 2018; Gong, 2021; Guseva and Weisser, 2018; Kabak, 2007; Kornfilt, 2012; Yoon, 2017). A largely independent line of research has evolved around subword coordination involving derivational morphology and compounds in Western Germanic (Artstein, 2005; Booij, 1985; Chaves, 2008; Höhle, 1982; Smith, 2000; Wiese, 2000). Pivots of any nature can be either to the right of the coordination, as seen earlier, or to the left, as in (10), where the pivot is *pro-*:

(10) pro-choice and -gun control (Chaves, 2008:263)

Right-hand and left-hand pivots have different properties (Chaves, 2008; Smith, 2000); here, we focus on the former.

Under the lexicalist assumption that syntax can only operate on words, coordination of word parts would need to be regarded as a purely morphological phenomenon. Accordingly, subword RNR has sometimes been analyzed not as the result of a genuine syntactic operation but of a prosodic deletion process which eliminates the string or phonological constituent corresponding to the pivot in the non-final conjunct(s) (e.g., Booij, 1985; Chaves, 2014; Höhle, 1982; Wilder, 1997), similar to some analyses of phrasal RNR. As we will see in

Section 4, such an approach is not tenable across the board. Instead, we will see evidence that, like phrasal RNR, subword RNR needs to be analyzed either as the result of a genuinely syntactically licensed ellipsis operation or of multidominance (for the latter analysis of subword RNR, see Wilder, 2008). A final approach to subword RNR that we will consider is the base generation analysis, according to which the pivot simply combines directly with the coordination of remnant and correlate (11) (Artstein, 2005; Dolatian, 2022; Gong, 2021; Kabak, 2007):

(11) [[pre and post] war]

In the following, we will not argue against the base generation analysis in general, which might or might not be correct for some cases of subword RNR in some languages. However, we will present several data points that are not compatible with either base generation or prosodic deletion but rather suggest either a multidominance or an ellipsis structure.

Before doing so, a few words on some additional complications. First, subword RNR is subject to prosodic well-formedness constraints, although the precise nature of these constraints remains controversial. For Dutch, German, and Chinese, it has been argued that pivots must be at least the size of a prosodic word (Booij, 1985; Féry, 2025; Guo, 2026; Höhle, 1982; Wiese, 2000; but see Neu, to appear), and for English, Artstein (2005) has claimed that they must be at least the size of a foot. Second, subword RNR is degraded if the word parts involved in it are not composed in a semantically transparent fashion (Chaves, 2008):

(12) a. *I caught butter- and fireflies.

b. *We bought an hour- and a looking-glass.

c. *We need more floor- and cupboards. (Chaves, 2008:274)

This fact falls out naturally under the assumption that a pivot must receive the same semantic interpretation in both conjuncts (Chaves, 2008; Neu and Guo, 2026). Such a constraint can be easily motivated under any analysis of RNR, and it can be shown independently to hold for both subword RNR (13a) and phrasal RNR (13b):

(13) a. *There stood a one- and well-armed man.

b. *I put the money, while Roger left the boat, in the bank. (Chaves, 2008:274)

In short, the seemingly idiosyncratic restrictions on subword RNR are merely a reflection of a general constraint holding on RNR more broadly.

The point that this paper aims to make does not hinge on these two additional restrictions on subword RNR. Our argument will rest on certain examples of subword RNR that are acceptable and can receive a certain interpretation. The fact that subword RNR is sometimes blocked for either PF- or LF-related reasons does not indicate that it is an underlyingly distinct phenomenon from phrasal RNR. In the next section, we look at the structural parallel between the two more in detail.

4 Mixed properties of subword RNR

4.1 Multidominance properties

As shown earlier, phrasal RNR allows for a distributive plural interpretation. Example (14a) can mean that Ava and Habib studied one Oceanic language each, a reading that is unavailable in the full coordination in (14b).

(14) a. Ava will soon, and Habib is going to, study Oceanic languages.

b. Ava will soon study Oceanic languages, and Habib is going to study Oceanic languages. (Belk et al., 2023:700)

The same pattern holds for subword RNR (Artstein, 2005). Example (15a) can mean that William is a sociolinguist and Lila a psycholinguist, whereas (15b) is only compatible with the reading that William and Lila are both psycholinguists and sociolinguists, that is they both have multidisciplinary careers.

(15) a. William and Lila are socio- and psycholinguists.

b. William and Lila are sociolinguists and psycholinguists.

A distributive reading is not easily accessible in either subword or phrasal RNR. However, it is strictly unavailable in the full coordinations, and we argue, in line with the literature, that this asymmetry requires an explanation.

As seen in Section 2 for the phrasal cases, an ellipsis or prosodic deletion analysis of RNR fails to account for distributive plurals since the relevant reading is unavailable

in the full coordinations. In response, Artstein (2005) has argued that a distributive plural interpretation in subword RNR must instead be derived from a base generation structure such as (16):

(16) [William and Lila] are [[socio- and psycho] linguists].

To account for the distributive reading, Artstein proposes a semantics according to which *linguists* takes two plural arguments – $[\![\text{socio}]\!] \oplus [\![\text{psycho}]\!]$ and $[\![\text{William}]\!] \oplus [\![\text{Lila}]\!]$ – and relates them in a distributive fashion, such that each part of *psycho and socio* must be related to at least one part of *William and Lila*, and vice versa (see also Beck and Sauerland, 2000; Winter, 2000).

Omitting the formal details of the analysis, we focus here on a simple problem, which is that (16) is not the correct constituency structure. Words like *sociolinguists* constitute a bracketing paradox: while the prosodic constituency is as in (17a), the morphosyntactic constituency is as in (17b) since compounding and derivational morphology precede inflectional morphology.[2]

(17) a. ((socio) (linguists)) b. [[socio linguist] s]

If one were to maintain a base generation analysis after all, the representation of (15a) would be as in (18):

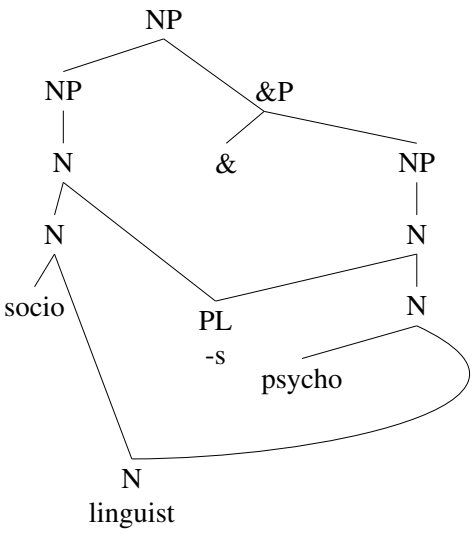
(18) [[[socio- and psycho] linguist] s]

[2]This argument does not apply to Artstein's analysis in particular, which relies on a mechanism he labels phonological decomposition. This mechanism allows syntax to coordinate meaningless strings and is thus not constrained by morphosyntactic constituency. However, phonological decomposition vastly overgenerates, and it would entail that syntax does not need to operate on a finite set of discrete atoms; for a more detailed critique, see Neu and Guo (2026).

Assuming that this structure is interpretable, [[*socio- and psycho*] *linguist*] would denote a single linguist with two specializations. Pluralizing this denotation, we derive the meaning of two or more people who are both psycholinguists and sociolinguists. This is the collective reading. Thus, a base generation analysis that respects morphosyntactic constituency, as in (18), cannot account for distributive readings either.

Thus, the only remaining option is a multidominance analysis. Recall that for phrasal RNR, Belk et al. (2023) and Barros and Vicente (2011) argued that a distributive reading can be derived from a multidominance structure in conjunction with QR. Crucially, we argue that for subword RNR, QR is unavailable. A possible multidominance structure for *socio- and psycholinguists* is shown in (19). We here represent *sociolinguists* and *psycholinguists* as complex heads, but nothing hinges on this.

(19)



Since *linguists* is not a constituent, we need to posit two pivots, *linguist* and plural *s*. Accordingly, even if QR of a word part was in principle possible – defying the ban on

extraction out of words –, it could not apply in this structure because there is simply no plural constituent, regardless of its category or its status as a head or a phrase, that could raise. Moving the plural morpheme only would not be an instance of QR, and it is not clear what the interpretative effects of this operation would be.

The finding that a distributive reading in subword RNR cannot be derived from a QR'ed multidominance structure might be taken to indicate that it must have a different source than distributive readings in phrasal RNR and that the analogy between the two kinds of variants of RNR that we are pursuing here is mistaken. However, we further note that it is not at all clear how a distributive reading falls out from a high scope of a plural noun in phrasal RNR either, which neither Belk et al. (2023) nor Barros and Vicente (2011) elaborate on. We cannot exclude that QR might prove helpful after all in deriving distributive plurals for at least phrasal RNR, but so far, this has not been shown, and for the subword cases, it is clearly a dead end.

To take stock, there is wide agreement that distributive readings for any type of RNR cannot be derived via any sort of ellipsis or deletion operation, and we have argued that a base generation analysis and the recently popularized multidominance-cum-QR strategy fail as well, at least for subword RNR. As mentioned, there are strong arguments against an ATB-movement analysis in general. This is a dispiriting outcome. For moving forwards, we suggest that an in-situ multidominance structure might be the most promising starting point for deriving distributive readings in both phrasal and subword RNR, also considering that the second property considered to be indicative of a multidominance structure in RNR,

cumulative agreement as seen earlier in (7), has never been analyzed in terms of QR but always in an in-situ multidominance structure (Belk et al., 2023; Chaves, 2014; Grosz, 2015; Yatabe, 2003, a.o.).

4.2 Ellipsis properties

Recall that morphological mismatch and vehicle change are suggestive of an ellipsis analysis of RNR (Barros and Vicente, 2011; Belk et al., 2023; Bošković, 2004; Citko, 2017, a.o.). The relevant examples, repeated from (5), are given below as (20).

(20) a. I usually fail to ~~wake up early~~, but Ava always succeeds in waking up early.

b. She hopes that he won't ~~fire her~~, but I fear that the boss will fire Ava.

(Belk et al., 2023:689f.)

Subword RNR equally exhibits morphological mismatch and vehicle change patterns:

(21) a. Yosho has over-~~estimated the cost of the plan~~ and Yin will underestimate the cost of the plan.

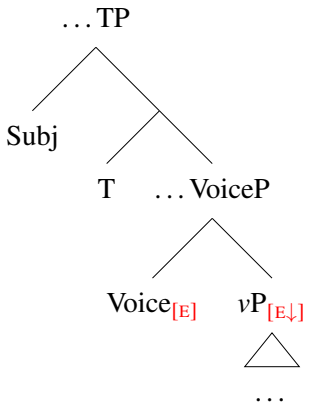
b. She$_1$ hopes that he will over~~pay her~~$_1$, but I know that the boss will underpay Ava$_1$.

To date, no existing analysis provides a satisfactory account of the data in (21). On the one hand, as discussed in the previous section, a multidominance analysis assumes that the shared material consists of a single syntactic element simultaneously dominated by both conjuncts. Consequently, it is not compatible with morphological mismatches or vehicle

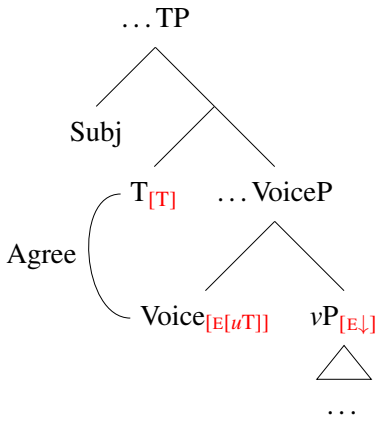
change. On the other hand, PF-deletion analyses, including both ellipsis and prosodic deletion approaches, likewise fail to account for the patterns in (21), albeit in different ways.

Consider first ellipsis. Under the approach developed by Zagona (1988) and Lobeck (1995, 1999), and subsequently adopted by Merchant (2001), among others, ellipsis is licensed when the the licensing head and the ellipsis site stand in a head–complement configuration, as in (22). By contrast, Aelbrecht (2010) proposes that the licensor enters into an Agree relation with an intermediate functional head bearing an [E]-feature, which in turn licenses the deletion of its complement, as in (23). In what follows, a constituent bearing [E↓] is understood to be muted at PF.

(22)



(23)



Despite these theoretical differences, both approaches share the crucial assumption that ellipsis targets syntactic constituents, such as *v*P in both (22) and (23). However, subword RNR examples like (21) pose a challenge to this assumption. First, in examples such as (21), the shared material does not constitute a single syntactic constituent. Second, the shared material contains a subword unit. Although an entire *v*P could in principle constitute a subword unit if the other subword were evacuated, extracting material out of words is expected to be banned, and it is not clear where such material would move. Moreover, cases like (21) contrast with those captured directly by syntactically licensed ellipsis, where the elided material invariably forms a single constituent. Consequently, examples such as (21) cannot be straightforwardly accommodated within standard constituent-based theories of ellipsis.

Consider next the prosodic deletion approach. From a narrower perspective, even analyses that advocate prosodic deletion for RNR, such as Hartmann (2001), Wilder (1997) and Chaves (2014), do not treat prosodic deletion and ellipsis as competing accounts of the same empirical domain. Prosodic deletion does not require its target to be a syntactic constituent: it can apply to any pair of peripheral strings that are morphologically identical and

prosodically independent (Chaves, 2014:838). Wilder (1997) explicitly argues that prosodic deletion requires phonological identity between the deleted material and its postcedent. Cases involving morphological mismatch and vehicle change continue to be analyzed as instances of syntactic ellipsis. Thus, a prosodic deletion analysis is not intended to account for RNR constructions involving morphological mismatch or vehicle change in the first place.

From a broader perspective, prosodic deletion neither accounts for the RNR data that motivate an ellipsis analysis nor explains the full range of empirical phenomena that support a multidominance analysis. Under a linearization-based deletion analysis, examples such as (24a) and (24b) can be derived by deleting prosodically independent material without reference to syntactic constituency.

(24) a. Mary flattered, and Bill disparaged, John excessively. (Belk et al., 2023:703)

b. Your theory under- and my theory over-generates data. (Wilder, 2008:248)

However, these examples do not necessarily provide evidence in favor of a prosodic deletion analysis but can also be accommodated within a multidominance framework by assuming multiple multidominance (see Belk et al., 2023; Wilder, 2008, a.o.). Furthermore, unlike multidominance, a prosodic deletion analysis fails to account for RNR constructions that give rise to distributive or cumulative interpretations. From the perspective of explanatory adequacy and theoretical economy, therefore, there is little motivation for adopting a prosodic deletion analysis as the primary account of RNR.

Lastly, Belk et al. (2023) have argued that the data from morphological mismatches and vehicle change should be analyzed as an instance of a PF-operation that they label

pruning (see also Neeleman and Ackema, 2026). While pruning might ultimately emerge as a promising avenue, it is not itself a solution to the problem we are facing here. Very broadly, pruning suppresses the pronunciation of one or more syntactic branches under identity with branches of their antecedent or postcedent, while leaving the underlying syntactic structure intact. Thus, it appears more flexible than standard versions of constituency ellipsis in the elements that it can target, which might allow it to account for our subword data as well. However, this flexibility also poses a problem. Belk et al. (2023, p. 716) assume that pruning is licensed independently of [E], raising the question of how pruning can rule out ellipsis patterns that the [E] system readily excludes. For instance, under Belk et al.'s formulation, nothing appears to rule out examples such as (25b):

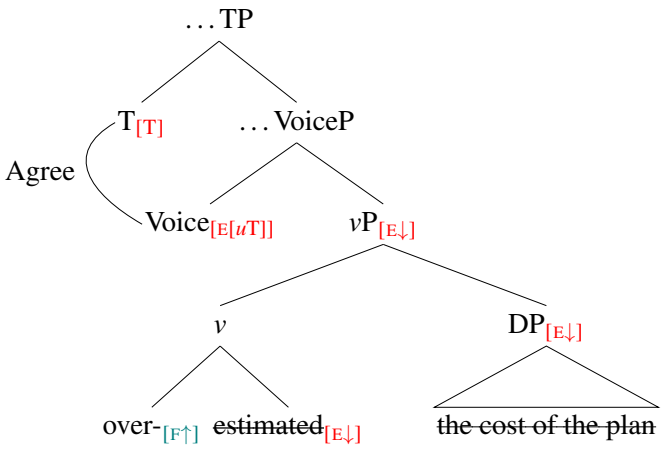
(25) a. Abdel talked to someone, but I don't know to whom ~~Abdel talked t~~$_{\text{to whom}}$.

b. *Abdel talked to someone, but I don't know to whom Abdel ~~talked t~~$_{\text{to whom}}$.

It might be possible to impose restrictions on pruning that allow for subword RNR while blocking examples such as (25b). Such restrictions would likely need to be similar to those independently imposed on syntactically licensed ellipsis. To date, however, no such system has been achieved.

Here, we suggest a different idea for how to maintain the idea that ellipsis drives morphological mismatches and vehicle change: examples like (21) are derived via RNR-E, but with a revised characterization of the material targeted for ellipsis. We propose that material bearing focus can survive ellipsis (see also Griffiths, 2019; Rooth, 1992a, 1992b; Takahashi and Fox, 2005, i.a.), as in (26) for (21a):

(26)



We argue that VP ellipsis in the backward direction in the RNR cases under consideration is licensed by the same licensors as VP ellipsis in the forward direction. Accordingly, in (26), T remains the licensor of VP ellipsis, while the ellipsis site is *v*P (Aelbrecht, 2010). For relevant examples showing that the same licensors are operative in both forward and backward ellipsis, see Bošković (2004). In (26), a constituent bearing [F↑] has a focus feature that prevents it from being muted. Note that our analysis still adopts Merchant's (2001) treatment of the [E]-feature, while proposing that an [F↑]-bearing element can shield itself from [E]-induced muting, in the spirit of Landau (2020a).

As illustrated in (26), we do not argue that the remnant *over-* moves out of the ellipsis site prior to deletion, an operation that would in any case be unexpected for a word part. Rather, *over-* remains in situ within the ellipsis site (see also Bruening, 2015; Griffiths, 2019; Griffiths et al., 2023; Ott and Struckmeier, 2018; Weir, 2014, a.o.). Moreover, we maintain that the material undergoing ellipsis still constitutes a syntactic constituent, despite surface appearances to the contrary. This apparent mismatch results from the fact that the element bearing the focus feature suppresses the application of the [E]-feature that would otherwise

apply to it.[3]

Like the subword cases discussed in (21), the phrasal examples in (27) have likewise not received a satisfactory explanation in previous analyses of RNR:

(27) a. %John immensely enjoyed ~~some of the talks on RNR~~, but few other people liked, any of the talks on RNR. (Sabbagh, 2007:363)

b. *John immensely enjoyed some of the talks on RNR, but few other people immensely enjoyed/liked ~~any of the talks on RNR~~.

Although example (27a) features a morphological mismatch characteristic of ellipsis, the relevant ellipsis pattern – namely, one in which the verbs are stranded outside the ellipsis site – is unattested in English forward ellipsis, as illustrated in (27b). Under the present proposal, however, the pattern in (27a) can still be derived through ellipsis: the elision operation applies as usual, while the focus-marked material is exempt from deletion and therefore remains overt.

Although in the subword (21) and phrasal (27a) examples seen so far, the stranded remnants and their correlates may bear a pitch accent and are interpreted as parallel focus

[3]Our proposal seems to predict (ia) to be acceptable, since both *over-* and *greatly* bear focus features that can escape ellipsis in situ. However, this prediction is not borne out.

(i) a. *Yosho has OVER-~~estimated the cost of the plan~~ GREATLY, and Yin will UNDERestimate the cost of the plan SLIGHTLY.

b. Yosho has GREATLY OVER-~~estimated the cost of the plan~~, and Yin will SLIGHTLY UNDER-estimate the cost of the plan.

We assume that all RNR constructions, whether analyzed as RNR-E or RNR-MD, must satisfy the Right-Edge Condition (Sabbagh, 2007; Wilder, 1997, 2008, a.o.), which requires the gap in a non-final conjunct, such as A in (ii), to occur at the right edge of its conjunct.

(ii) [$_{A}$ . . . gap] Conj [$_{B}$ . . . pivot]

This condition independently rules out (ia). We leave the question why ellipsis constructions are subject to the Right-Edge Condition for future research.

alternatives (*over-* vs. *under-* and *enjoyed* vs. *liked*, respectively), this accent need not be contrastive (see also Chaves, 2014). We argue that additive focus (König, 1977, 1981; Zimmermann, 2014, a.o.) also qualifies an element for in-situ survival, as illustrated below.

(28) a. %Yosho has over~~estimated the cost of the plan~~, and Yin will **also** overestimate the cost of the plan.

b. *Yosho has over~~estimated the cost of the plan~~, and Yin will overestimate the cost of the plan.

The morphological mismatch between *-estimated* and *-estimate* in (28a) is indicative of an ellipsis analysis. Here, *over-* can be stranded despite lacking a contrastive relation with *over-* in the second conjunct. Although judgments of (28a) vary, the presence of *also* clearly improves the example relative to (28b), which is categorically unacceptable. We therefore suggest that the additive particle *also* is associated with focus alternatives, which license a pitch accent within the second conjunct of (28a), where material would otherwise be given and deaccented (28b). We leave the precise nature of this relation for future research.

So far, we have assumed that forward ellipsis (VP ellipsis) and backward ellipsis (RNR-E) are derived via the same mechanism. However, they also differ: verbal material – either a subpart of the verb, as in (21)/(28a), or a full-sized verb, as in (27a) – can be stranded under backward, but not under forward ellipsis (see also Landau, 2020a, 2020b a.o.).

(29) a. *John immensely enjoyed some of the talks on RNR, but few other people immensely liked/enjoyed ~~any of the talks on RNR~~.

b. *Yosho has overestimated the cost of the plan, and Yin will under~~estimate the~~

~~cost of the plan~~.

To account for this asymmetry, we propose that the difference follows from how remnants survive ellipsis. As argued above, under backward ellipsis, the remnant – whether a subpart of the verb or the full verb – remains in situ when ellipsis applies; see (26). By contrast, we propose that under forward ellipsis, verbal material must move out of the ellipsis site to survive, such that verb movement is a necessary precursor to verb stranding or to VP ellipsis, following Harwood (2014) and Thoms (2010) (see also Benbaji-Elhadad and Pesetsky, 2024, a.o.).

Under this analysis, in (27a), the focused verbal material can be stranded under backward ellipsis because it need not move out of the ellipsis site prior to ellipsis; rather, it survives ellipsis in situ. In (29a), by contrast, although the verbal material likewise bears focus, the corresponding in-situ stranding strategy is unavailable under forward ellipsis. To survive ellipsis, the verb would therefore have to undergo movement out of the ellipsis site. Given that the ellipsis site in English VP ellipsis is *v*P, as shown in (22) and (23), stranding under forward ellipsis would require the verb to move to a higher functional head outside *v*P. English lexical verbs, however, do not undergo such movement (Emonds, 1978; Pollock, 1989). The same reasoning extends to the contrast between (28a) and (29b): a subpart of the verb can be stranded under backward ellipsis by remaining in situ, whereas such in-situ stranding is unavailable under forward ellipsis, and the verbal subpart cannot independently undergo movement. We therefore attribute the asymmetry between backward and forward ellipsis to a fundamental difference in the mechanism by which verbal material can survive

ellipsis: backward ellipsis permits in-situ survival of the relevant (verbal) material, whereas forward ellipsis requires such material to move outside the ellipsis site prior to ellipsis.

Our proposal raises the broader question why forward and backward ellipsis should permit different mechanisms of remnant survival (in situ vs. ex situ). While solving this question is beyond the scope of this paper, we believe that future work should aim to link this syntactic asymmetry to two other differences between forward and backward ellipsis: processing and prosody. First, in backward ellipsis (RNR-E), the postcedent follows the ellipsis site, so the parser must maintain an unresolved dependency until it is encountered. By contrast, in forward ellipsis, the antecedent precedes the ellipsis site, alleviating the processing difficulty. How the two types of ellipsis are processed might affect their syntactic realization. Second, RNR has a distinctive prosodic profile: it is typically accompanied by pitch accent on the stranded material and its correlate and by a rising boundary tone at the end of each conjunct. It might be that focus-marked material is able to survive in situ in backward ellipsis in order to provide a host for this prosodic marking. Overall, we hope that the differences between forward and backward ellipsis in terms of remnant survival can be related to differences between the two constructions in other domains.

In sum, we propose that a refined implementation of ellipsis provides the most promising account of the exceptional subword and phrasal RNR patterns illustrated in (21) and (27a), respectively, given that neither multidominance nor prosodic deletion successfully captures the relevant data. Specifically, we propose that backward and forward ellipsis are subject to parallel licensing and identification conditions, but that unlike forward ellipsis,

backward ellipsis permits focus-marked material to survive ellipsis under the application of the [E]-feature that would otherwise license ellipsis. The ellipsis site is initially established as a syntactic constituent, but its surface realization may depart from the expected pattern when the requirements of contrastive or additive focus override the effect of the [E]-feature.

5 Conclusion

This paper has been concerned with a curious variant of RNR in which the pivot is smaller than a word. We have shown that subword RNR displays the same mixed properties that for phrasal RNR have been taken as evidence for a dual account as either multidominance or ellipsis. However, we have also argued that the specific ways in which these properties have been analyzed for the case of phrasal RNR do not carry over to subword RNR. First, distributive plural readings in subword RNR, while indeed suggestive of a multidominance structure, cannot be derived via QR, and we have further highlighted that its usefulness for phrasal RNR is not clear either. Second, morphological mismatches and vehicle change in subword RNR, while indeed evidence for ellipsis, cannot be captured by standard VP ellipsis. In response to the latter predicament, we have proposed a novel approach to backward ellipsis according to which focus-marked constituents can survive ellipsis while remaining in-situ. Overall, the broader point we have made is that any successful analysis of the syntax of RNR also needs to be able to account for subword RNR. We hope that this paper stimulates more research on RNR that attempts to capture shared properties at the word and at the subword level in a single, unified framework.

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